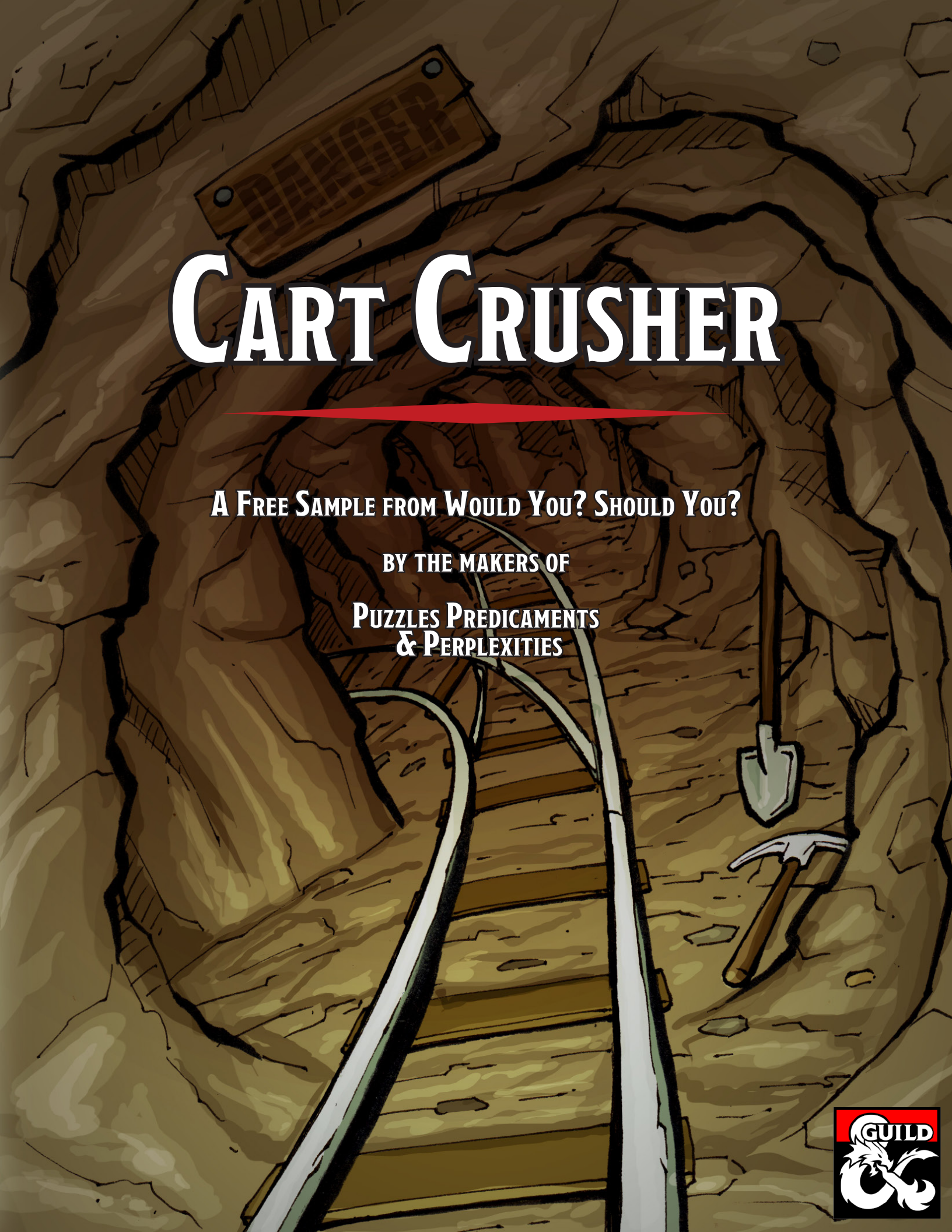


Cart Crusher

A Free Sample from Would You? Should You?

by the makers of

Puzzles Predicaments & Perplexities

GUILD

Credits

Writing & Design: Steve “Jaspor” Orr, @AgentJaspor, Bill Putrino, @bputrino & DJ Brewer
Producer: Steve “Jaspor” Orr
Cover Illustration:
Editing: Steve “Jaspor” Orr
Layout: DJ Brewer
Interior artwork: Shutterstock/Firstear
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About The Authors

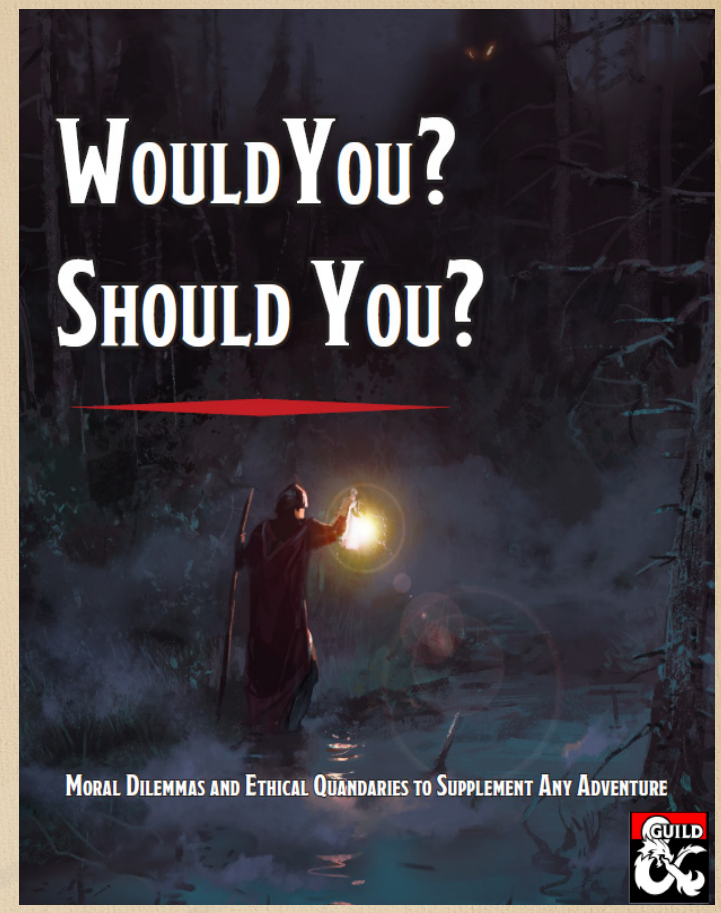
Bill Putrino is a pop punk skateboarder living the good life in the world of nerdy pop culture. Bill is an avid Board Gamer, RPG player, and DM, not to mention an amazing artist as you can tell by his work on his site dnd2d.com.

Steve “Jaspor” Orr is a homebrewer, retired punk rock guitarist, and software developer. Steve has been playing and DMing D&D games for many years, and has been publishing on the Dungeon Masters Guild since February 2019. One day he might even learn how to draw more than just stick figures.

D.J. Brewer is a humble public servant, defined by his love of video games, beer, and occasionally working out at the gym. A longtime fantasy geek, D.J. is determined to become a layout pro, or at least not have to search how to do basic layout functions.

FULL PRODUCT

Would You, Should You? is a collection of short encounters meant to present player characters with interesting, thought provoking, and difficult ethical choices.



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Introduction

Choices aren't true dilemmas when everyone would do the same thing in your situation. Stop the marauding orcs from harming an innocent family. Slay the beholder before it enslaves your friends. Those choices are easy. But what about when the path isn't entirely clear? How about torturing an innocent person to ensure the happiness and health of an entire village? What about sacrificing an unsuspecting stranger to save many lives, or revealing truths about someone's past that may bring harm to a good person?

Would You, Should You? is a collection of short encounters meant to present player characters with interesting, thought provoking, and difficult ethical choices. This free sample – Cart Crusher – is just one of the eight scenarios available in the full product. Insert this classic ethical dilemma anywhere in a campaign and watch the sparks fly!

What's In The Full Book?

The full *Would You, Should You?* provides eight encounters to be inserted into any campaign where solving a difficult moral question may be appropriate. The encounters themselves are short enough that they may be used in a variety of scenarios, including setting up a larger quest, as a temporary break in the action during a campaign, as a fork-in-the-road flashpoint during travel or exploration, or in any other way an enterprising Dungeon Master might imagine.

Some encounters include options to tweak the details, allowing Dungeon Masters to sway the party one way or the other. Be care of your decisions, as many encounters include potential short- and long-term consequences the party should face for their actions or inactions.

Encounters available in the full product include:

Needs of the many. The party encounters a village paradise whose happiness comes a disturbing price. Should the happiness of an entire village come at the suffering of an innocent victim?

Cart Crusher (included). The party must make a split-second choice between letting a runaway mining cart kill a group of miners or actively switching the tracks to kill just one.

The Streets Demand Justice. A mob of angry elves forms outside town hall, demanding justice for the killing of one of their own at the hands of a human. The party must decide whether or not to offer up an innocent man to a bloodthirsty mob to avert wider bloodshed.

Chasing the Throat-Slitter. A local prince has placed the party in charge of a task force to apprehend a notorious war criminal known as "The Throat-Slitter," who stages increasingly brutal attacks against the populace. The party must balance its need to stop the Throat-Slitter's deadly plots against the possibility of causing collateral damage.

An Ugly Truth. When an upstanding community leader asks the party to take care of an unfortunate situation, the party realizes there might be some deep dark secrets at play. The truth could harm the person who has done much good, but do the people close to her deserve to know the truth?

Fly Or Die. An innocent citizen has been captured by an evil warlock and is being held in their stronghold built into a volcano. They plan to sacrifice the poor captive in a dark ritual. The party arrives just in time to stop the ritual, but the way the sacrificial chamber is built, they must choose between saving the captive from certain death or making sure the villain does not escape.

Eat the Rich. The party makes its way to a small village that has a clear dividing line between extremely wealthy and impoverished residents. After witnesses the arrest of a local hero, the party must choose between doing what is legal or helping the poor.

A Father's Love, A Child's Loss. The party can save a son's life by sacrificing the willing father, but nobody in town wants to help the man kill himself.

Heavy Material

Some of the details of these encounters deal with weighty subjects, such as the deaths of loved ones, friends, and innocent people. This makes each choice feel difficult and impactful. If some are uncomfortable with such choices as, say, killing a father to save the son, DMs have the option of adjusting details to fit each player's comfort level



Cart Crusher

A rope pulling a mining cart laden with heavy ore snaps, sending the cart barreling towards a group of workers. The party must make a split-second choice between letting the runaway cart continue to kill the group or switching the tracks to kill just one.

The adventurers happen upon a dwarven mining encampment during their travels.

Read or paraphrase the following to set up the dilemma:

The outside of the mine is shaped like a giant bowl dug into the ground, with several mine shafts tunneled into the earth at various points throughout the encampment. Ramps, pulleys, and tracks cross everywhere, as the dwarves work with amazing efficiency mining ore and hauling it up and out of the encampment to be refined.

As you approach closer, you observe the dwarves going about their business with an industrial fervor. Some dwarves work on laying a new track into a recently opened shaft. Higher along the track, several sturdy dwarves pull a heavy cart laden with ore out of the mine. Suddenly, the rope the dwarves are using to pull the cart snaps, sending the workers tumbling. The cart barrels back down the tracks, with a few of the exasperated dwarves vainly running in tow.

The cart easily leaves the dwarves behind and blazes past you. The hilarious scene instantly turns tragic as you now notice that the cart is headed directly for the five track-laying dwarves. The workers are all much too far away to hear anything and are oblivious to the danger heading towards them. They will all surely die. There is a fork in the track, however, leading to a lone dwarf preparing some empty carts to be sent back into another shaft. Having bent over to remove something from the last cart, the dwarf is waist deep and upside down, his legs dangling in the air; his back turned to the action.

You are near a lever that shifts between the two tracks. The lever has been set to lead to the track with the five workers, which is where the cart heads if you do nothing. If you pull the lever, however, the cart diverts into the lone dwarf who is retrieving something from the cart, killing him.

Alternative Scenario

This dilemma provides two variations on the same scenario. The choices and outcomes are nearly the same, but the lead up is slightly changed in one version to introduce the lone dwarf to the party. Perhaps the party might choose differently if they personally know one of the would-be victims?

The Dilemma

The party must choose to pull the lever or do nothing. When the cart breaks, the players are located next to the lever along the tracks. The lever has two simple arrows indicating which track is currently selected. Players who succeed on a DC 8 Intelligence (Investigation) or Wisdom (Insight) check confirm that the track is currently set to hit the group of workers, and that by pulling the lever, the cart is diverted to the other track.

The cart rapidly accelerates and is moving so quickly there is no time for the player characters to make any other actions other than deciding whether or not to pull the lever. The party may make the decision together or individually. See the Conflicting Choices sidebar on how to conduct the scenario in a turn-based format.

Any attempt to use magical or non-magical means to stop the cart, alert the dwarves, or disrupt the track is nearly impossible (DC 23) due to a variety of factors:

- The cart and track are of sturdy dwarven make, and resist almost all direct magical attacks.
- The sheer speed of the cart and the limited amount of time to react puts incredible stress on the characters.
- The dwarves are so busily engaged in their work and are so far away that any attempt to communicate with them fails.

Conflicting Choices

If the DM chooses, this scenario can be conducted over one combat round. Players roll for initiative and, in-turn, decide whether to pull the lever or pass. The cart starts at the top of the track at the beginning of the turn, and travels approximately 100 feet to reach the unfortunate victims by the end of the turn. When it is their turn, characters may elect to undo the previous character's decision by pulling the lever back! This continues until all players have completed their turn, at which point the cart will have smashed into its victim(s).

Choices And Outcomes

If the party pulls the lever, the cart diverts and crushes the poor dwarf. Read or paraphrase the following.

> With no time to hesitate, you pull the lever and switch the tracks. At the last second, the cart turns and smashes into the dwarf's legs and backside that had been dangling out of the cart. He is crushed. You just killed an innocent person to save others.

If the party does nothing, the cart continues down its path and smashes into the five dwarves laying track. Read or paraphrase the following:

> You decide not to pull the lever and let the cart continue. The speeding cart crashes into the dwarves at a terrifying clip, severing arms and legs and sending bodies flying before it finally smashes into the end of the short mine shaft. All five dwarves lay lifeless in a pile of body parts and corpses.

Incentives and Reservations



Most parties are likely to elect to kill lone dwarf to save the group. Spice things up and make the choice a bit harder by introducing the lone dwarf to the party at the beginning of the scenario. This forces the party to choose saving one dwarf they know versus a group of strangers. DMs may create a backstory for the lone dwarf or use the following to begin the alternate version of the scenario:

> The outside of the mine is shaped like a giant bowl dug into the ground, with several mine shafts tunneled into the earth at various points throughout the encampment. Ramps, pulleys, and tracks cross everywhere, as the dwarves work with amazing efficiency mining ore and hauling it up and out of the encampment to be refined.
>
> As you approach closer, you meet a young dwarf who is enjoying a short break in the shade of a small tree. Sweat glistens from his ruddy brow and his dark auburn red beard is matted with mining dust. "Ahh, travelers!" he smilingly shouts in a thick dwarven accent; "come on over and take a load off." You gladly sit and swap news with the young dwarf, who introduces himself as Rufus Redstone. Rufus shares some of his sweet dwarven ale with you. "Here!" he laughs, "this should wash out some of that road dust from your throat." After a few moments, the dwarf looks up and says "well, time for me to get back to work. But before I go, let me get ye a couple more pints for the road. Don't worry, the company pays for it all." Rufus runs to a nearby mining cart and begins searching for your ale.

Another method is to make the group of five dwarves less likable. This can be done prior to the scenario by introducing the five dwarves in a way that shows them to be surly drunken louts who act with aggression and anger to the party. Perhaps the party previously met this group in a tavern or some other encounter under unpleasant circumstances. A little prep work here could make the decision much more enjoyable and difficult.

Long-Term Consequences

If the party decides to kill the lone dwarf, they find out he was the youngest son of a local dwarven king named Ludvar Ulfhammer. Ludvar is nicknamed "The Mad" due to his propensity to sponsor lavish building projects and gaudy events, and – more to the point – to throw perceived enemies off the highest peak in his kingdom. It isn't long before Mad King Ludvar learns the details of his son's death and begins plotting his revenge against the party.

If the group spares the lone dwarf, he reveals himself to be the son of Mad King Ludvar and provides a signed invitation to be the guests of honor at the next Festival of Autumn's End to be held in his hometown of Bavarn. What unforeseen adventures might befall the party should they choose to cash in on this invitation?

Alternative Details

The details and setting of this scenario can be changed to fit a variety of circumstances, although the choice should always come down to killing one or letting many die. Some possible scenario changes include:

- In a city, pulling a lever to lower a gate to stop an out of control wagon headed for a group of people. The wagon crashes into the gate, killing the driver, but the group is spared.
- Using a gate to divert a rampaging monster or animal headed for a group of people. If you close the gate, the monster or animal heads along a side route to gore a lone person.



Appendix A: Magic Items

(six in full product)

Bow Of Friendly Fire

Weapon (longbow), very rare (requires attunement)

A blood red bow with a black bow string. This bow gains strength by stealing the health of friendly party members. The wielder of this bow can sense that the bow enjoys hurting your friends.

Friendly Fire. When you nock an arrow on this bow, it whispers in Infernal, "Friendly Fire?" then chuckles. When you use this weapon to make a ranged attack, you can use 1 of 3 command words to increase the damage of the attack. "Hurt them, but be nice," "Hurt them," or "Bring the pain."

Each party member within 60 feet of you takes damage equal to your command word's damage.

Add the damage amount from your command word, times the number of your party members within 60 feet of you to your rolled damage.

Friendly Fire can be used once per combat.

"Hurt them, but be nice" = 3 damage.

"Hurt them" = 4 damage.

"Bring the paint" = 5 damage.

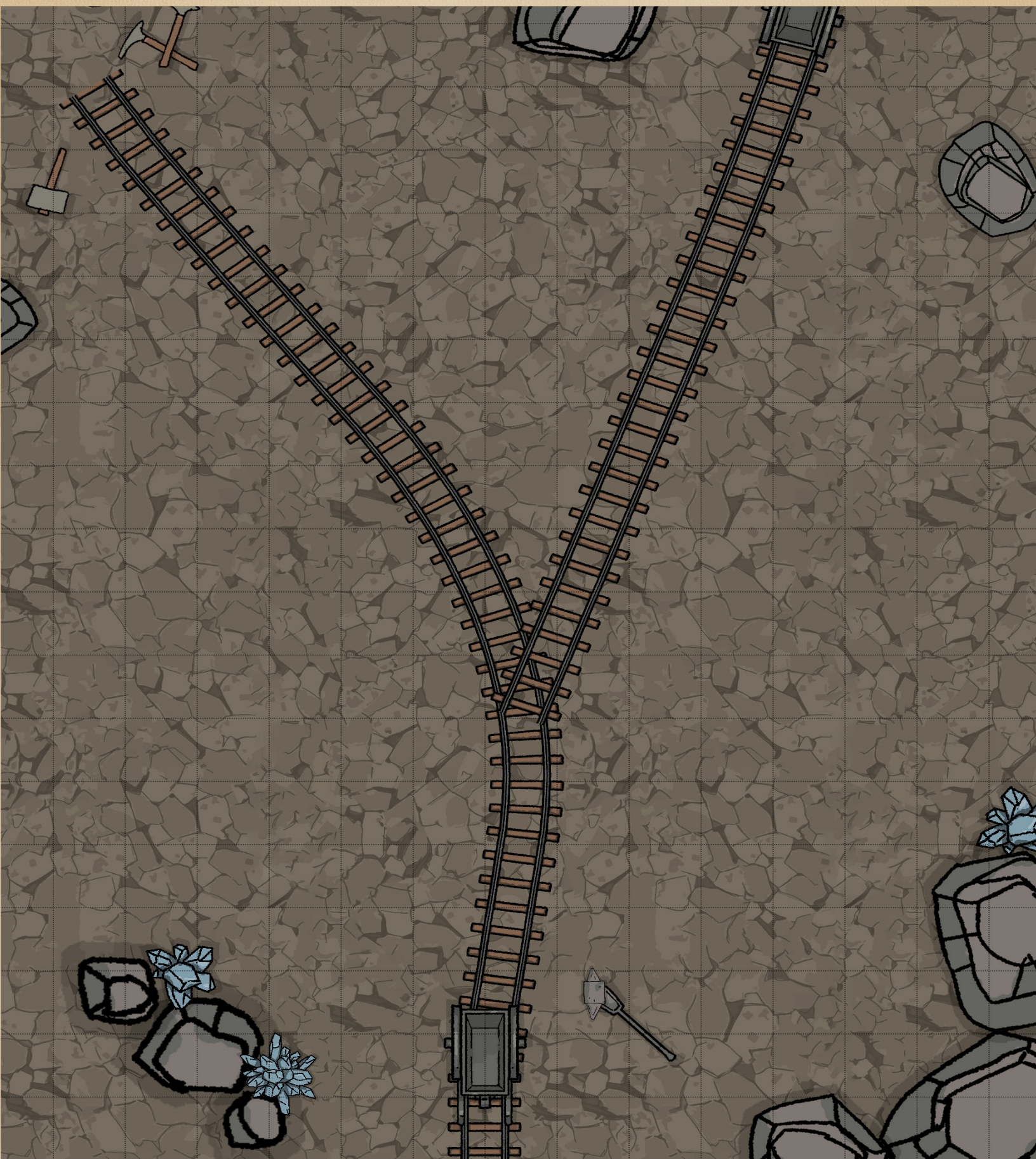
Disa-Re-Appearing Gold

Wonderous Item, very rare (requires attunement)

Ordinary looking set of 25 gold pieces. Any gold pieces from the set that are 500 feet away from its attuned character for 24 hours disappear from their current location and reappear in the pocket of the attuned character. In order for the gold to reappear, the character and gold must be on the same plane of existence.

Appendix C: Maps

Cart Crusher (three in full product)



Beyond Good & Evil

Would you reveal the deep dark secret of a seemingly good person in order to ensure those that depend on her know the truth? Should you pull the lever to divert a runaway mine cart so it doesn't kill five unaware dwarves only to kill a single dwarf who is currently safe from the danger? Should you save the captive who is about to plunge into a pit of lava, but let the dangerous villain escape and cause further death and destruction?

Would You? Should You? is a collection of scalable standalone encounters that present the party with difficult moral dilemmas and complex ethical quandaries. These encounters are designed to be placed into any campaign or adventure and offer guidance on customizing them to make the choices even more difficult than they may initially appear on the surface.

A Dungeons & Dragons supplement for adventures of all levels and types to be used by Dungeon Masters.



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